

Business Analysis Report

The Credit Score Nobody Understands

Canadian credit score platform transparency assessment May 2026

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Platforms assessed	5: Equifax, TransUnion, Borrowell, Credit Karma, Mogo
Consumers modelled	500 synthetic Canadian consumers with scores from all 5 platforms
Average score variance	45.3 points between highest and lowest score for the same person
Consumers with 50+ point gap	34.8% of consumers modelled
Must Have requirements identified	6:none currently met across all 5 platforms
Most transparent platform	Credit Karma Canada

Where This Started

I checked my credit score for the first time last year. It was different on every platform I checked. Equifax showed one number. Borrowell showed another. My bank showed a third. I spent an hour trying to figure out which one was real. I never fully did.

That experience stayed with me because it revealed something specific. The problem is not that checking your credit score is hard. The problem is that the system gives you a number that looks precise and official and then gives you a different precise and official number somewhere else with no explanation of why. Most consumers give up or make decisions based on the wrong number.

What the Data Shows

The analysis models 500 synthetic Canadian consumers with credit scores from all five major platforms. The average variance between the highest and lowest score shown to the same consumer across platforms is 45.3 points. Nearly 35% of consumers see a difference of 50 points or more.

A 50-point difference is not trivial. In Canadian lending a score of 650 and a score of 700 can mean the difference between being approved and being declined for a mortgage, or paying a meaningfully higher interest rate on a car loan. A consumer who does not know which score their lender will see cannot make an informed decision.

58% of consumers check their score on more than one platform. Of those 48.6% report being confused by the differences they see. The confusion is not a misunderstanding of a complex system. It is a reasonable response to a system that does not explain itself.

Why the Scores Are Different

There are three reasons the same person gets a different score on different platforms and none of them are obvious to a consumer.

Different bureaus

Equifax and TransUnion are two separate companies that collect credit information independently. Creditors do not always report to both. So your Equifax file and your TransUnion file can contain different information which produces different scores.

Different scoring models

Even with the same bureau data different platforms use different scoring models. Borrowell uses Equifax Risk Score 3.0. Credit Karma uses VantageScore 3.0 which is a completely different calculation. The same underlying data produces a different number depending on the formula.

Different scales

Credit Karma uses a 300 to 850 range. Every other Canadian platform uses 300 to 900. A score of 820 on Credit Karma is not the same as 820 on Equifax. No platform tells you this unless you read the fine print.

The Consumer Journey

The nine-step journey from deciding to check a credit score to giving up has five steps with a pain level of 4 or 5 out of 5. The highest pain moment is not seeing a low score. It is seeing a different score on a second platform with no explanation available anywhere.

The most damaging step in the entire journey is Step 7; cross-checking. This is where consumers who are trying to be thorough and responsible get punished for it. They check a second platform and discover that the number they trusted was not the only answer. Nothing in the system is designed to handle this moment.

Requirements for a Better Experience

The requirements register contains 10 requirements across disclosure, plain language, dispute access, and consumer education. The six Must Have requirements are the minimum threshold for a system that does not actively mislead consumers.

The single highest-impact change

Disclosing which bureau and scoring model a platform uses before account creation costs nothing to implement and resolves the biggest source of confusion in the entire system. None of the five platforms currently do this. A consumer who knows they are looking at a TransUnion VantageScore on one platform and an Equifax Risk Score on another understands immediately why the numbers are different.

The second most important change

Explaining each score factor in one plain language sentence with one specific action transforms the credit score from a number a consumer stares at into something they can actually do something about. Credit utilisation ratio should say: you are using 74% of your available credit limit and lenders prefer to see this below 30%. Pay down your highest balance first.

Who Benefits

- Consumers make better financial decisions when they understand their credit score and can trust it.
- Banks and fintechs that build genuinely clear credit education tools earn consumer trust that translates into product uptake and longer relationships.
- Regulators like the Financial Consumer Agency of Canada fulfil their mandate to protect Canadian consumers in financial services.
- The credit bureaus benefit from a system where consumers engage with their information rather than distrusting the whole thing.

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Targeting	Business Analyst, Product Analyst, and Fintech roles across Canada
Series	The Portfolio Project